



The quality of play steadily improved. Both semifinals were tightly contested, with the second one decided on a Golden Point in the 15th and final game. In the league stage, 11 of 20 ties ended with either 8-7 or 9-6 scorelines. The semifinal qualification cut-off was 41 points — the highest in the last three seasons.

All eight teams fought fiercely for every point, and controversies naturally followed — over let calls, questionable service motions, and close edge-ball decisions that challenged even the keenest eyes.

“The review system was recently trialled at the ITTF World Cup and the ITTF World Championships but hasn’t been implemented fully. Hopefully, once it becomes permanent on the WTT circuit, we may see it in upcoming UTT seasons too,” said Desai.

Some coaches and players also advocated for the inclusion of one-minute timeouts, already standard on the international circuit.

John Murphy, coach of champion U Mumba, suggested a tweak to the tie format: “Instead of following the set sequence of men’s singles, women’s singles, mixed doubles, reverse men’s singles and reverse women’s singles, the team winning the toss should be allowed to choose

whether to start with a male or female player. For a team like us with Bernadette Szocs, we’d want her to open the tie. It could also prevent the final singles from always being a women’s match.”

Jorg Bitzigeio, coach of the bottom-placed Stanley’s Chennai Lions, called for an end to player retentions in future auctions. “Among Indian male players, two (Desai and Sathiyan) are strong in both singles and doubles, offering more tactical options. Others are either still developing in one format or the other. These two have always been retained [Sathiyan wasn’t retained but stayed at Dabang]. It’s better if there’s no retention,” he said.

Attracting more global stars and top coaches doesn’t seem to be a concern for UTT.

Indian paddlers have shown marked improvement in international results since the league’s inception in 2017 — winning 15 Commonwealth Games medals, three at the Asian Games, and seven at the Asian Championships.

But when it comes to the financial health of franchises, the picture is mixed. The league expanded from six to eight teams last year. For UTT

High-octane: Dabang Delhi’s Maria Xiao and G. Sathiyan in action against Goa Challengers’ Zeng Jian and Harmeet Desai during UTT Season 6 in Ahmedabad. VIJAY SONEJI

6, ThunderBlades replaced Bengaluru Smashers and Puneri Paltan rebranded as PBG Pune Jaguars.

“Goa have made money. Like that, if the franchises put in little effort, they’ll all break even soon,” said Dani on the morning of the final. “You may have noticed that many of these franchises now have started getting sponsors, reflected by their jerseys. That’s a sign that people believe in our model, the game and the league as a property.

“Of course, it will take a little time but we are moving in the right direction and quickly. For us, as league owners, our ROI is in how Indian table tennis does more than financials because we are not here to only make money. It is more important that as a country, we do well.”

Across six editions, there have been 16 franchises. Of these, only the Challengers have turned a profit — largely thanks to their back-to-back titles in 2023 and 2024.